



WHAT IS INSANITY?



Insanity literally means “sickness of mind.” Another word for insanity is madness. An insane person behaves in ways that other people consider abnormal, irrational, or crazy. It is an all-encompassing label that includes extreme forms of mental illness, such as paranoia (imagining people are following you or wanting to harm you) or schizophrenia (hearing aggressive voices inside your head), as well as eccentric but relatively harmless types of behavior.

PAST TREATMENT

In the past, those people considered insane were locked up in asylums. They were called lunatics (from *luna*, the Latin for “moon”) because their symptoms were thought to worsen during a full moon. In 18th-century Europe, fashionable people would visit lunatic asylums and laugh at the antics of the inmates, who were regarded as similar to wild creatures. Insanity is no longer an accepted medical diagnosis. Instead, doctors today recognize and treat a wide range of mental disorders. These include mild anxiety and mood disorders, such as panic attacks, phobias, eating disorders, depression, and mood swings, as well as more serious mental illnesses.

ALL PSYCHED UP

Any word that has *psych* at the front means that it has to do with the mind. A psychiatrist is a doctor who treats mental illness, a psychologist is a scientist who studies the human mind, and a psychopath is a person with a severe mental disorder, often with criminal or violent tendencies. Psychopaths are unable to show emotion or relate normally to other people. They lack

a sense of wrongdoing, so they take huge risks and do not recognize society’s rules and punishments. Experts estimate that between three and five percent of people show psychopathic tendencies. Although psychopaths often easily tell lies and struggle to keep a job, only a tiny proportion go on to become serial killers, despite their stereotyped portrayals in movies and on television. Some mental disorders are conditions for life, with no outright cure, but most can be managed and treated successfully with the use of drugs, counseling, and other therapies. This allows sufferers to lead relatively normal lives.



MADNESS OF GENIUS

Roman philosopher Seneca (c. 4 BCE–64 CE) said, “There is no great genius without some touch of madness.” Throughout history, some great minds have walked a fine line between genius and insanity. Examples include Dutch painter Vincent van Gogh (1853–1890), who was plagued by depression and cut off part of his ear, before taking his own life. One of history’s great thinkers, Sir Isaac Newton (1643–1727) probably suffered from psychotic tendencies and mood swings. The story of troubled schizophrenic and Nobel Prize-winning economist John Forbes Nash (1928–) was made famous in the movie *A Beautiful Mind*. Though there is some evidence of a link between genius and insanity, no one has proved this beyond all doubt. Historians continue to research the mental conditions of past geniuses by analyzing their works, letters, and other people’s testimonies in order to discover whether madness played a role in their achievements.